

The Most Dangerous Game

Richard Connell · 1924

First published: Collier's, 19 Jan 1924

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

Indiana 2023 edition (standards shown for this framework only)

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

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Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson 1: introduction (author, context, reception, overview)
4. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
5. Unit test (eleven rigor versions) with answer keys and scoring guides
6. Final paper
7. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/O._Henry_Memorial_Award_Prize_Stories_of_1924/The_Most_Dangerous_Game (revision 12072546), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 8–10 (scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). Middle School prompts use the full text when the grade tags include 6–8; otherwise teacher-selected passages. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 2 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does The Most Dangerous Game suggest about hunter and hunted?
- What does The Most Dangerous Game suggest about civilization and savagery?
- What does The Most Dangerous Game suggest about survival?

Objectives

- Cite textual evidence to support analysis of what the text says explicitly and implicitly.
- Determine themes and analyze their development over the course of the story.
- Analyze how characters, setting and point of view interact.
- Determine the meaning of words and phrases as they are used in the text.
- Write arguments to support claims with clear reasons and relevant evidence.

Standards: Indiana 2023

7.RC.2, 7.RC.3, 7.W.1, 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.RC.2, 9-10.RC.3, 9-10.RC.9, 9-10.RC.12, 9-10.W.1, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.4, 11-12.RC.11, 11-12.RC.13, 11-12.W.1

Indiana Academic Standards, English/Language Arts (2023), IDOE

Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one

essay of the five

Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Middle School through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.

Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	*Introduction: author, context and reception* The Most Dangerous Game	2 × 90 min (180 min)	*hunter and hunted* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Introduction: author, context and reception • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: Introduction to The Most Dangerous Game

Author biography

Richard Connell was born in Poughkeepsie, New York, on 17 October 1893. He reported for newspapers as a teenager, graduated from Harvard, worked in advertising and served in France in the First World War. He became a prolific magazine writer and Hollywood screenwriter; his story for Meet John Doe (1941) earned an Academy Award nomination. He died in Beverly Hills on 22 November 1949.

Historical and cultural context

Written after the First World War, in which Connell served, and at the height of the fashion for big-game hunting safaris among wealthy Americans and Europeans. General Zaroff is a Cossack aristocrat who fled the Russian Revolution of 1917.

Publication and reception, then and now

First published in Collier's on 19 January 1924; it won the O. Henry Memorial Award.

Then: An instant popular success, filmed in 1932.

Now: One of the most-taught stories in American schools, the model of suspense and the source of countless "human hunt" plots.

Overview (spoiler-free)

Rainsford, a famous big-game hunter, falls overboard near the mysterious Ship-Trap Island and finds the château of General Zaroff, who has grown bored with hunting animals.

Main themes

- hunter and hunted.
- civilization versus savagery.
- reason and instinct.

Why it matters

It asks students to think about empathy and violence, and teaches suspense and conflict.

Spoilers · teacher only

Zaroff hunts shipwrecked men; he hunts Rainsford for three days. Rainsford escapes by leaping into the sea, ambushes Zaroff in his bedroom, and the story ends with Rainsford sleeping in Zaroff's bed, implying he killed him.

Lesson plan (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)

Before we open The Most Dangerous Game: Is hunting animals for sport different from hunting for food?
Prompt: Before we open The Most Dangerous Game: Is hunting animals for sport different from hunting for food?

8–18 min · Key terms · I do (10 min)

conflict; suspense; foreshadowing; irony; character foil.

18–28 min · Mini-lecture: author, context, reception · I do (10 min)

About the author. Richard Connell was born in Poughkeepsie, New York, on 17 October 1893. He reported for newspapers as a teenager, graduated from Harvard, worked in advertising and served in France in the First World War. He became a prolific magazine writer and Hollywood screenwriter; his story for Meet John Doe (1941) earned an Academy Award nomination. He died in Beverly Hills on 22 November 1949. The world of the book. Written after the First World War, in which Connell served, and at the height of the fashion for big-game hunting safaris among wealthy Americans and Europeans. General Zaroff is a Cossack aristocrat who fled the Russian Revolution of 1917. Publication and reception. First published in Collier's on 19 January 1924; it won the O. Henry Memorial Award. Then: An instant popular success, filmed in 1932. Now: One of the most-taught stories in American schools, the model of suspense and the source of countless "human hunt" plots.

28–40 min · I do: the book in one passage · I do (12 min)

"The world is made up of two classes—the hunters and the huntees" (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 14). Rainsford's early view.

> *The world is made up of two classes—the hunters and the huntees (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 14)*

Think-aloud: "The world is made up of two classes—the hunters and the huntees" (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 14). Rainsford's early view.

40–55 min · We do: overview and themes · We do (15 min)

What the book is about (no spoilers): Rainsford, a famous big-game hunter, falls overboard near the mysterious Ship-Trap Island and finds the château of General Zaroff, who has grown bored with hunting animals. Themes to track: hunter and hunted.: civilization versus savagery.: reason and instinct.:

55–70 min · You do: reading journal · You do (15 min)

Set up a reading journal: one page per theme with a prediction and a question.
Task: Set up a reading journal for The Most Dangerous Game: one page per theme, each with a prediction and a question.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)

Why does The Most Dangerous Game still matter? It asks students to think about empathy and violence, and teaches suspense and conflict.
Anchor question: Why might The Most Dangerous Game still be taught today?
Facilitation: It asks students to think about empathy and violence, and teaches suspense and conflict.

80–87 min · Exit ticket · You do (7 min)

How does Rainsford's view change? Answer: He learns what it feels like to be hunted, though he ends by killing Zaroff.
Exit ticket: How does Rainsford's view change?
Answer: He learns what it feels like to be hunted, though he ends by killing Zaroff.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)

Tomorrow we begin reading: The Most Dangerous Game.

Teacher notes · sources: Britannica, "Richard Connell" (https://www.britannica.com/biography/Richard-Connell); O. Henry Prize Stories history (https://www.penguinrandomhouse.com/series/OHP/the-o-henry-prize-stories/)

Flags (verify before teaching):

- Content note: violence and a hunted human; Zaroff's servant Ivan and some references reflect period stereotypes. Collier's date commonly cited; verify.

Lesson 2: The Most Dangerous Game

Focus: the hunter becoming the hunted

Objective: Students will analyze how conflict develops in "The Most Dangerous Game" by writing a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph that cites at least 2 quotations from the section, and will score at least 80% on the section quiz.

Standards: CCSS RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1, L.9-10.4 · IN 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.9, 9-10.RC.11

Content note (killing of humans for sport, violence): Sensitive content: Killing of humans for sport; violence. Preview the story, tell students in advance, and allow a pass on reading aloud. Keep discussion on how the writer uses these elements, not on graphic detail.
Student preview: Heads-up: this story includes killing of humans for sport; violence.
Suggested language: "Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?"

Teacher only · spoilers

Big-game hunter Sanger Rainsford falls overboard near Ship-Trap Island and finds the chateau of General Zaroff, a Russian aristocrat bored with hunting animals who now hunts shipwrecked sailors. Rainsford refuses to join and becomes the prey for three days. He builds traps that kill a servant and a hound, then leaps into the sea. That night he waits in Zaroff's bedroom; they fight, and Rainsford sleeps in Zaroff's bed.

Background: Published in Collier's on 19 January 1924, after the First World War, in which Connell served. Big-game safaris were a fashionable sport.

Significance: Among the most anthologized American stories; it appears in Glencoe's grade 9 lesson plans and Gale's Short Stories for Students, vol. 1.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Is it ever acceptable to hunt for sport? Where would you draw the line? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to hunter and hunted because.... Content note before we start: Heads-up: this story includes killing of humans for sport; violence.
Prompt: Is it ever acceptable to hunt for sport? Where would you draw the line?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to hunter and hunted because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: Rainsford learns empathy through terror.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: canopied — covered overhead like a canopy; focused — fixed; concentrated (on a target); loudness — the quality of being loud; bizarre — conspicuously or grossly unconventional or unusual; wrestled — combat to overcome an opposing tendency or force. "focused": Latin focus "hearth, fireplace"; see there for more. Related to fuel.
Words: canopied: covered overhead like a canopy · focused: fixed; concentrated (on a target) · loudness: the quality of being loud · bizarre: conspicuously or grossly unconventional or unusual · wrestled: combat to overcome an opposing tendency or force

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Published in Collier's on 19 January 1924, after the First World War, in which Connell served. Big-game safaris were a fashionable sport. Among the most anthologized American stories; it appears in Glencoe's grade 9 lesson plans and Gale's Short Stories for Students, vol. 1. Foreshadowing: Ship-Trap Island's reputation and Rainsford's dismissal of animals' feelings. Irony: The hunter becomes the hunted; Zaroff's "civilized" manners hide savagery. Conflict: Man versus man, and man versus nature. Watch for the island: a trap; Zaroff's world.

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "The world is made up of two classes—the hunters and the huntees" (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 14). His early philosophy. That is foreshadowing at work: Ship-Trap Island's reputation and Rainsford's dismissal of animals' feelings.

> *The world is made up of two classes—the hunters and the huntees (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 14)*

Think-aloud: I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "The world is made up of two classes—the hunters and the huntees" (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 14). His early philosophy. That is foreshadowing at work: Ship-Trap Island's reputation and Rainsford's dismissal of animals' feelings.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: Zaroff's belief. Look at the craft: The hunter becomes the hunted; Zaroff's "civilized" manners hide savagery. Ask: How does this line connect to hunter and hunted? Expected: Rainsford learns empathy through terror. (Zaroff's belief.)

> *Instinct is no match for reason (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 95)*

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: Zaroff's belief. Look at the craft: The hunter becomes the hunted; Zaroff's "civilized" manners hide savagery.
Ask: How does this line connect to hunter and hunted?
Expected answer: Rainsford learns empathy through terror. (Zaroff's belief.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)

Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).

Annotate the story for foreshadowing, irony (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about the hunter becoming the hunted? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how The Most Dangerous Game develops the idea of the hunter becoming the hunted. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of conflict and foreshadowing shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: Rainsford's early view is turned against him. When the text says "The world is made up of two classes—the hunters and the huntees" (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 14), it shows this directly. He tells Whitney "The world is made up of two classes—the hunters and the huntees," and Zaroff makes him a huntee; at the end, "He had never slept in a better bed," suggesting he has become a hunter of men too.

Task: Annotate the story for foreshadowing, irony (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about the hunter becoming the hunted? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how The Most Dangerous Game develops the idea of the hunter becoming the hunted. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of conflict and foreshadowing shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)

Exemplar: Rainsford's early view is turned against him. When the text says "The world is made up of two classes—the hunters and the huntees" (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 14), it shows this directly. He tells Whitney "The world is made up of two classes—the hunters and the huntees," and Zaroff makes him a huntee; at the end, "He had never slept in a better bed," suggesting he has become a hunter of men too.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)

Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.

Anchor question: Is it ever acceptable to hunt for sport? Where would you draw the line? Ask: has Rainsford become like Zaroff?

Anchor question: Is it ever acceptable to hunt for sport? Where would you draw the line?

Facilitation: Ask: has Rainsford become like Zaroff?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)

Story quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).

Story quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about the hunter becoming the hunted? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Rainsford's early view is turned against him. ("The world is made up of two classes—the hunters and the huntees", The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 14). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about the hunter becoming the hunted? Support it with one short quotation.

Answer: Model answer: Rainsford's early view is turned against him. ("The world is made up of two classes—the hunters and the huntees", The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 14). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

> **87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)**
> Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
> *Today we saw how foreshadowing shapes the hunter becoming the hunted. Key takeaway: Rainsford learns empathy through terror.*

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Foreshadowing:** Ship-Trap Island's reputation and Rainsford's dismissal of animals' feelings.
- **Irony:** The hunter becomes the hunted; Zaroff's "civilized" manners hide savagery.
- **Conflict:** Man versus man, and man versus nature.

Themes and how they develop

- **hunter and hunted:** Rainsford learns empathy through terror.

Symbols and motifs

- **the island:** a trap; Zaroff's world.

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- "The world is made up of two classes—the hunters and the huntees" (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 14) His early philosophy.
- "Instinct is no match for reason" (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 95) Zaroff's belief.
- "He had never slept in a better bed, Rainsford decided" (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 211) The ending.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

> **Claim:** Rainsford's early view is turned against him.
> **Evidence:** "The world is made up of two classes—the hunters and the huntees" (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 14)
> **Reasoning:** He tells Whitney "The world is made up of two classes—the hunters and the huntees," and Zaroff makes him a huntee; at the end, "He had never slept in a better bed," suggesting he has become a hunter of men too.

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
canopied (verb)	covered overhead like a canopy	*It was to a huge, beam-ceilinged bedroom with a canopied bed big enough for six men that*	

		Rainsford followed the silent giant.	
focused (verb)	fixed; concentrated (on a target)	*Toward morning when a dingy gray was varnishing the sky, the cry of some startled bird focused Rainsford's attention in that direction.*	"focused": Latin focus "hearth, fireplace"; see there for more. Related to fuel. (Wiktionary, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/focus#Etymology)
loudness (noun)	the quality of being loud	*He let it fall, and it startled him with its booming loudness.*	
bizarre (adjective)	conspicuously or grossly unconventional or unusual	*Rainsford's first impression was that the man was singularly handsome; his second was that there was an original, almost bizarre quality about the general's face.*	
wrestled (verb)	combat to overcome an opposing tendency or force	*He wrestled himself out of his clothes, and shouted with all his power.*	
complimented (verb)	praised	*When I shot some of his prize turkeys with it, he did not punish me; he complimented me on my marksmanship.*	
protruding (verb)	extend out or project in space	*His foot touched the protruding bough that was the trigger.*	
affable (adjective)	diffusing warmth and friendliness	*He was finding the general a most thoughtful and affable host, a true cosmopolite.*	"affable": French affable, from Latin affābilis, from affor "to address", from ad + for "to speak, to talk". See fable. By surface analysis, af- + fable. (Wiktionary, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/affable#Etymology)
crouched (verb)	bend one's back forward from the waist on down	*Then, wet with sweat and aching with tiredness, he crouched behind the stump of a lightning-charred tree.*	
luckily (adverb)	by good fortune	*I, luckily, had invested heavily in American securities, so I shall never have to open a tea room in Monte Carlo or drive a taxi in Paris.*	

Discussion questions

1. Is it ever acceptable to hunt for sport? Where would you draw the line?

2. Where does conflict appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with hunter and hunted?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. How does Rainsford reach the island? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1, 9-10.RC.1] Look for: He falls off a yacht and swims ashore
2. What does Zaroff hunt? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1, 9-10.RC.1] Look for: Human beings
3. What is Ship-Trap Island known for? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1, 9-10.RC.1] Look for: Sailors' dread of it
4. How long must Rainsford survive to win? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1, 9-10.RC.1] Look for: Three days
5. Where does the story end? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1, 9-10.RC.1] Look for: In Zaroff's bedroom, with Rainsford in the bed
6. Retell the three most important events of "The Most Dangerous Game" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1, 9-10.RC.1] Look for: Big-game hunter Sanger Rainsford falls overboard near Ship-Trap Island and finds the chateau of General Zaroff, a Russian aristocrat bored with hunting animals who now hunts shipwrecked sailors. Rainsford refuses to join and becomes the prey for three days. He builds traps that kill a servant and a hound, then leaps into the sea. That night he waits in Zaroff's bedroom; they fight, and Rainsford…
7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in "The Most Dangerous Game"? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1, 9-10.RC.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does "The Most Dangerous Game" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1, 9-10.RC.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: "It was to a huge, beam-ceilinged bedroom with a canopied bed big enough for six men that Rainsford followed the silent giant." What does "canopied" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1, 9-10.RC.1] Look for: canopied: covered overhead like a canopy.
10. Reread: "Toward morning when a dingy gray was varnishing the sky, the cry of some startled bird focused Rainsford's attention in that direction." What does "focused" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1, 9-10.RC.1] Look for: focused: fixed; concentrated (on a target).

Inferential / analytical

1. What does "The Most Dangerous Game" suggest about the hunter becoming the hunted? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2, 9-10.RC.2] Look for:

Among the most anthologized American stories; it appears in Glencoe's grade 9 lesson plans and Gale's Short Stories for Students, vol. 1.

2. Find one example of conflict in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2, 9-10.RC.1] Look for: Look for the forces, people or desires pulling against each other.
3. How does the foreshadowing in this story shape what we understand about the hunter becoming the hunted? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2, 9-10.RC.3] Look for: Look for hints, warnings or images that point to later events.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Rainsford's early view is turned against him. Useful evidence: “The world is made up of two classes—the hunters and the huntees” (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 14): His early philosophy. On foreshadowing: Ship-Trap Island's reputation and Rainsford's dismissal of animals' feelings. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. In the passage that begins “He struggled up to the surface and tried to cry out, but the wash from the speeding yacht slapped him in the face and the salt water in his open mouth made him gag and strangle.”, why might Connell have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · 7.RC.12, 7.CC.2, 9-10.RC.12] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in “The Most Dangerous Game”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2, 9-10.RC.1] Look for: Big-game hunter Sanger Rainsford falls overboard near Ship-Trap Island and finds the chateau of General Zaroff, a Russian aristocrat bored with hunting animals who now hunts shipwrecked sailors. Rainsford refuses to join and becomes the prey for three days. He builds traps that kill a servant and a…
6. As the opening story, what does “The Most Dangerous Game” set up that the rest of The Most Dangerous Game will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2, 9-10.RC.3] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Rainsford's early view is turned against him. Useful evidence: “Instinct is no match for reason” (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 95): Zaroff's belief. Theme link: Rainsford learns empathy through terror. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2, 9-10.RC.1] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Rainsford's early view is turned against him. Useful evidence: “He had never slept in a better bed, Rainsford decided” (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 211): The ending. Theme link: Rainsford learns empathy through terror. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. The bell-ringer asked: “Is it ever acceptable to hunt for sport? Where would you draw the line?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2, 9-10.RC.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does irony appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with hunter and hunted? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · 7.RC.1, 7.CC.2, 9-10.RC.1] Look for: Look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Rainsford's early view is turned against him. Useful evidence: “The world is made up of two classes—the hunters and the huntees” (The Most Dangerous

Game, paragraph 14): His early philosophy. On irony: The hunter becomes the hunted; Zaroff's "civilized" manners hide savagery. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

10. Background: Published in Collier's on 19 January 1924, after the First World War, in which Connell served. Big-game safaris were a fashionable sport. How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2, 9-10.RC.1] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Rainsford's early view is turned against him. Useful evidence: “Instinct is no match for reason” (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 95): Zaroff's belief. Theme link: Rainsford learns empathy through terror. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: “Among the most anthologized American stories; it appears in Glencoe's grade 9 lesson plans and Gale's Short Stories for Students, vol. 1.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3, 9-10.RC.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Rainsford's early view is turned against him. Useful evidence: “He had never slept in a better bed, Rainsford decided” (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 211): The ending. Theme link: Rainsford learns empathy through terror. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3, 9-10.RC.1] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Rainsford's early view is turned against him. Useful evidence: “The world is made up of two classes—the hunters and the huntees” (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 14): His early philosophy. Theme link: Rainsford learns empathy through terror. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

3. Rewrite one moment of “The Most Dangerous Game” from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about the hunter becoming the hunted? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · 7.RC.1, 7.CC.3, 9-10.RC.1] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Rainsford's early view is turned against him. Useful evidence: “Instinct is no match for reason” (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 95): Zaroff's belief. Theme link: Rainsford learns empathy through terror. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

4. Write three questions of your own about “The Most Dangerous Game”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3, 9-10.RC.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Rainsford's early view is turned against him. Useful evidence: “He had never slept in a better bed, Rainsford decided” (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 211): The ending. Theme link: Rainsford learns empathy through terror. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

5. Connect this story to civilization and savagery: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Connell need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3, 9-10.RC.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Rainsford's early view is turned against him. Useful evidence: “The world is made up of two classes—the hunters and the huntees” (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 14): His early philosophy. Theme link: Rainsford learns empathy through terror. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
6. Is the conflict in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3, 9-10.RC.1] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Rainsford's early view is turned against him. Useful evidence: “Instinct is no match for reason” (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 95): Zaroff's belief. On conflict: Man versus man, and man versus nature. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
7. Compare how “The Most Dangerous Game” treats the hunter becoming the hunted with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does The Most Dangerous Game see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3, 9-10.RC.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Rainsford's early view is turned against him. Useful evidence: “He had never slept in a better bed, Rainsford decided” (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 211): The ending. Theme link: Rainsford learns empathy through terror. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. As the final story, does this ending resolve hunter and hunted? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3, 9-10.RC.3] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Rainsford's early view is turned against him. Useful evidence: “The world is made up of two classes—the hunters and the huntees” (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 14): His early philosophy. On foreshadowing: Ship-Trap Island's reputation and Rainsford's dismissal of animals' feelings. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about the hunter becoming the hunted? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3, 9-10.RC.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Rainsford's early view is turned against him. Useful evidence: “Instinct is no match for reason” (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 95): Zaroff's belief. Theme link: Rainsford learns empathy through terror. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. What question would you most like to ask Richard Connell about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3, 9-10.RC.2] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Rainsford's early view is turned against him. Useful evidence: “He had never slept in a better bed, Rainsford decided” (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 211): The ending. Theme link: Rainsford learns empathy through terror. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Conflict:** look for the forces, people or desires pulling against each other (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Foreshadowing**: hints, warnings or images that point to later events
- Also notice **Irony**: gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "His foot touched the _____ bough that was the trigger." Word bank: focused, canopied, loudness, protruding
   Key: protruding
2. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "When I shot some of his prize turkeys with it, he did not punish me; he _____ me on my marksmanship." Word bank: complimented, canopied, focused, loudness
   Key: complimented
3. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 211: "He had never slept in a better bed, _____ decided"
   Key: Rainsford
4. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Where does the story end?
   A. In Zaroff's bedroom, with Rainsford in the bed
   B. On the yacht
   C. In the jungle
   D. At sea

   Key: A (In Zaroff's bedroom, with Rainsford in the bed)
5. [mc · recall · DOK 1] How does Rainsford reach the island?
   A. He falls off a yacht and swims ashore
   B. He is invited
   C. He is shipwrecked in a storm with friends
   D. His plane crashes

   Key: A (He falls off a yacht and swims ashore)
6. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "He was finding the general a most thoughtful and _____ host, a true cosmopolite." Word bank: focused, canopied, affable, loudness
   Key: affable
7. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What does Zaroff hunt?
   A. Wild boars
   B. Tigers
   C. Human beings
   D. Deer

   Key: C (Human beings)

8. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 14: “The world is made up of two _____—the hunters and the huntees”

   Key: classes

9. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What is Ship-Trap Island known for?

   A. Rare birds

   B. A lighthouse

   C. Sailors' dread of it

   D. Gold mines

   Key: C (Sailors' dread of it)

10. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “He _____ himself out of his clothes, and shouted with all his power.” Word bank: wrestled, focused, loudness, canopied

    Key: wrestled

11. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which choice best states a central concern of “The Most Dangerous Game”?

    A. Superstition used against a credulous man

    B. The hunter becoming the hunted

    C. Self-destruction and the urge to do wrong

    D. Friendship tested by duty

    Key: B (The hunter becoming the hunted)

12. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “Instinct is no match for reason” (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 95) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Zaroff's belief.

13. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “The world is made up of two classes—the hunters and the huntees” (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 14) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: His early philosophy.

14. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze the word choice in “He had never slept in a better bed, Rainsford decided” (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 211). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.

    Sample answer: The ending.

15. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “The Most Dangerous Game”? The hunter becomes the hunted; Zaroff's "civilized" manners hide savagery.

    A. Personification

    B. Theme

    C. Irony

    D. Symbolism

    Key: C (Irony)

16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “The world is made up of two classes—the hunters and the huntees” (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 14) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: His early philosophy.

17. [mc · recall · DOK 1] How long must Rainsford survive to win?

    A. A week

B. A month

C. Three days

D. One night

Key: C (Three days)

18. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 95: "_____ is no match for reason"

    Key: Instinct

19. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Claim: Rainsford's early view is turned against him. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: "The world is made up of two classes—the hunters and the huntees" (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 14).

    Sample answer: He tells Whitney "The world is made up of two classes—the hunters and the huntees," and Zaroff makes him a huntee; at the end, "He had never slept in a better bed," suggesting he has become a hunter of men too.

20. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in "The Most Dangerous Game"? Ship-Trap Island's reputation and Rainsford's dismissal of animals' feelings.

    A. Personification

    B. Foreshadowing

    C. Theme

    D. Symbolism

    Key: B (Foreshadowing)

21. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the story: "Rainsford's early view is turned against him." Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.

    Sample answer: He tells Whitney "The world is made up of two classes—the hunters and the huntees," and Zaroff makes him a huntee; at the end, "He had never slept in a better bed," suggesting he has become a hunter of men too.

22. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how hunter and hunted develops from an earlier story to "The Most Dangerous Game". Use one quotation from each.

    Sample answer: Rainsford learns empathy through terror.

23. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of "Instinct is no match for reason" (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 95) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: Zaroff's belief.

24. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line "Rainsford's first impression was that the man was singularly handsome; his second was that there was an original, almost bizarre quality about the general's face.", what does "bizarre" most nearly mean?

    A. covered overhead like a canopy

    B. conspicuously or grossly unconventional or unusual

    C. fixed; concentrated (on a target)

    D. the quality of being loud

    Key: B (conspicuously or grossly unconventional or unusual)

25. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line "He let it fall, and it startled him with its booming loudness.", what does "loudness" most nearly mean?

    A. the quality of being loud

    B. conspicuously or grossly unconventional or unusual

C. fixed; concentrated (on a target)

D. covered overhead like a canopy

Key: A (the quality of being loud)

26. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line "It was to a huge, beam-ceilinged bedroom with a canopied bed big enough for six men that Rainsford followed the silent giant.", what does "canopied" most nearly mean?

A. the quality of being loud

B. conspicuously or grossly unconventional or unusual

C. fixed; concentrated (on a target)

D. covered overhead like a canopy

Key: D (covered overhead like a canopy)

27. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line "Toward morning when a dingy gray was varnishing the sky, the cry of some startled bird focused Rainsford's attention in that direction.", what does "focused" most nearly mean?

A. the quality of being loud

B. covered overhead like a canopy

C. fixed; concentrated (on a target)

D. conspicuously or grossly unconventional or unusual

Key: C (fixed; concentrated (on a target))

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Middle School	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16	recall 10, inference 3, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	4, 7, 17, 3, 18, 2, 8, 10, 1, 12, 13, 11, 19, 14, 15, 16	recall 9, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	1, 10, 2, 7, 4, 5, 3, 18, 13, 11, 12, 15, 20, 19, 21, 22	recall 8, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	9, 17, 3, 1, 6, 4, 5, 12, 11, 13, 20, 15, 14, 19, 16, 21	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	3, 4, 17, 18, 2, 8, 13, 11, 12, 15, 20, 14, 19, 16, 22, 21	recall 6, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	4, 6, 2, 7, 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 15, 19, 14, 16, 22, 23, 21	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Freshman	10, 2, 24, 17, 25, 11, 13, 12, 15, 14, 19, 20, 21, 16, 22, 23	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Sophomore	8, 5, 9, 24, 2, 11, 13, 12, 15, 14, 19, 20, 23, 22, 16, 21	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Junior	10, 5, 24, 4, 2, 12, 13, 11, 14, 19, 15, 20, 23, 16, 22, 21	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Senior	10, 26, 4, 2, 7, 11, 13, 12, 20, 14, 19, 15, 23, 22, 16, 21	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
Graduate / PhD	27, 10, 2, 7, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 19, 20, 15, 22, 16, 21, 23	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; Indiana 2023: 7.RC.3, 7.W.1): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In "The Most Dangerous Game," how does Connell show the hunter becoming the hunted?

Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the conflict you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.W.1): In The Most Dangerous Game, how does Connell develop the idea of the hunter becoming the hunted? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the conflict in the story helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.W.1): Analyze how The Most Dangerous Game develops the idea of the hunter becoming the hunted. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of conflict and foreshadowing shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1): Analyze how the structure of The Most Dangerous Game (where it begins, turns and ends) and its conflict shape the reader's understanding of the hunter becoming the hunted. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1): Two readers disagree about what The Most Dangerous Game suggests about the hunter becoming the hunted. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's conflict and foreshadowing), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how Richard Connell uses conflict in The Most Dangerous Game to complicate the reader's understanding of the hunter becoming the hunted. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Indiana 2023: see unit standards): Situate The Most Dangerous Game within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of the hunter becoming the hunted responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Indiana 2023: see unit standards): Read The Most Dangerous Game alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of the hunter becoming the hunted follows or bends those conventions, using the conflict as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Indiana 2023: see unit standards): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to The Most Dangerous Game and its treatment of the hunter becoming the hunted. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's conflict and foreshadowing, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Indiana 2023: see unit standards): Develop a research argument that reads The Most Dangerous Game as evidence for a larger claim about the hunter becoming the hunted in The Most Dangerous Game. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Indiana 2023: see unit standards): Develop an original argument that reads The Most Dangerous Game as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of the hunter becoming the hunted. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on The Most Dangerous Game.

SAT-style questions

1. *He let it fall, and it startled him with its booming loudness.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “loudness” most nearly mean?

   A. bend one's back forward from the waist on down

   B. diffusing warmth and friendliness

   C. the quality of being loud

   D. by good fortune

2. *He struggled up to the surface and tried to cry out, but the wash from the speeding yacht slapped him in the face and the salt water in his open mouth made him gag and strangle. Desperately he struck out with strong strokes after the receding lights of the yacht, but he stopped before he had swum fifty feet. A certain cool-headedness had come to him; it was not the first time he had been in a tight place. There was a chance that his cries could be heard by someone aboard the yacht, but that chance was slender, and grew more slender as the yacht raced on. He wrestled himself out of his clothes, and shouted with all his power. The lights of the yacht became faint and ever-vanishing fireflies; then they were blotted out entirely by the night.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “The Most Dangerous Game”?

   A. The hunter becoming the hunted

   B. Love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence

   C. Reason struggling against terror

   D. The cost of wanting to seem richer than you are

SAT key: 1. C (the quality of being loud); 2. A (The hunter becoming the hunted)

Unit test

The Most Dangerous Game: end test · 90 minutes · 18 questions per rigor version (multiple choice, fill in the blank, short answer). The class rigor level picks the version; student auto-adjust applies.

Short-answer scoring guides

Middle School and HS Freshman (2 points): correct answer in a complete sentence with a detail from the text. HS Sophomore to HS Senior (3 points): claim, one accurate quotation, one sentence of explanation. AP to College Sophomore (4 points): precise claim, two embedded quotations, commentary on word choice or structure, link to theme. College Junior to Graduate (5 points): nuanced thesis, close reading of two passages, synthesis across sections, a competing reading answered. Each item lists a sample answer; partial credit is described in the app.

Unit test: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 14: “The world is made up of two _____—the hunters and the huntees”
   Key: classes
2. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 95: “_____ is no match for reason”
   Key: Instinct
3. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “His foot touched the _____ bough that was the trigger.” Word bank: focused, canopied, loudness, protruding
   Key: protruding
4. [mc · recall · DOK 1] How long must Rainsford survive to win?
   A. A week
   B. A month
   C. Three days
   D. One night
   Key: C (Three days)
5. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Where does the story end?
   A. In Zaroff's bedroom, with Rainsford in the bed
   B. On the yacht
   C. In the jungle
   D. At sea
   Key: A (In Zaroff's bedroom, with Rainsford in the bed)
6. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “When I shot some of his prize turkeys with it, he did not punish me; he _____ me on my marksmanship.” Word bank: complimented, canopied, focused, loudness
   Key: complimented

7. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 211: “He had never slept in a better bed, _____ decided”

   Key: Rainsford

8. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “He was finding the general a most thoughtful and _____ host, a true cosmopolite.” Word bank: focused, canopied, affable, loudness

   Key: affable

9. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What does Zaroff hunt?

   A. Wild boars

   B. Tigers

   C. Human beings

   D. Deer

   Key: C (Human beings)

10. [mc · recall · DOK 1] How does Rainsford reach the island?

    A. He falls off a yacht and swims ashore

    B. He is invited

    C. He is shipwrecked in a storm with friends

    D. His plane crashes

    Key: A (He falls off a yacht and swims ashore)

11. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “He _____ himself out of his clothes, and shouted with all his power.” Word bank: wrestled, focused, loudness, canopied

    Key: wrestled

12. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What is Ship-Trap Island known for?

    A. Rare birds

    B. A lighthouse

    C. Sailors' dread of it

    D. Gold mines

    Key: C (Sailors' dread of it)

13. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “Instinct is no match for reason” (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 95) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Zaroff's belief.

14. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which choice best states a central concern of “The Most Dangerous Game”?

    A. Superstition used against a credulous man

    B. The hunter becoming the hunted

    C. Self-destruction and the urge to do wrong

    D. Friendship tested by duty

    Key: B (The hunter becoming the hunted)

15. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “The world is made up of two classes—the hunters and the huntees” (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 14) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: His early philosophy.

16. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Claim: Rainsford's early view is turned against him. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “The world is made up of two classes—the hunters and the huntees” (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 14).
    Sample answer: He tells Whitney "The world is made up of two classes—the hunters and the huntees," and Zaroff makes him a huntee; at the end, "He had never slept in a better bed," suggesting he has become a hunter of men too.
17. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze the word choice in “He had never slept in a better bed, Rainsford decided” (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 211). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.
    Sample answer: The ending.
18. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how hunter and hunted develops from an earlier story to “The Most Dangerous Game”. Use one quotation from each.
    Sample answer: Rainsford learns empathy through terror.
19. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “The Most Dangerous Game”? Ship-Trap Island's reputation and Rainsford's dismissal of animals' feelings.
    A. Personification
    B. Foreshadowing
    C. Theme
    D. Symbolism

    Key: B (Foreshadowing)
20. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “The world is made up of two classes—the hunters and the huntees” (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 14) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: His early philosophy.
21. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “Instinct is no match for reason” (The Most Dangerous Game, paragraph 95) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: Zaroff's belief.
22. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “The Most Dangerous Game”? The hunter becomes the hunted; Zaroff's "civilized" manners hide savagery.
    A. Personification
    B. Theme
    C. Irony
    D. Symbolism

    Key: C (Irony)
23. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the story: “Rainsford's early view is turned against him.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.
    Sample answer: He tells Whitney "The world is made up of two classes—the hunters and the huntees," and Zaroff makes him a huntee; at the end, "He had never slept in a better bed," suggesting he has become a hunter of men too.
24. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Rainsford’s first impression was that the man was singularly handsome; his second was that there was an original, almost bizarre quality about the general’s face.”, what does “bizarre” most nearly mean?
    A. covered overhead like a canopy
    B. conspicuously or grossly unconventional or unusual

C. fixed; concentrated (on a target)

D. the quality of being loud

Key: B (conspicuously or grossly unconventional or unusual)

25. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line "Toward morning when a dingy gray was varnishing the sky, the cry of some startled bird focused Rainsford's attention in that direction.", what does "focused" most nearly mean?

A. the quality of being loud

B. covered overhead like a canopy

C. fixed; concentrated (on a target)

D. conspicuously or grossly unconventional or unusual

Key: C (fixed; concentrated (on a target))

26. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line "It was to a huge, beam-ceilinged bedroom with a canopied bed big enough for six men that Rainsford followed the silent giant.", what does "canopied" most nearly mean?

A. the quality of being loud

B. conspicuously or grossly unconventional or unusual

C. fixed; concentrated (on a target)

D. covered overhead like a canopy

Key: D (covered overhead like a canopy)

27. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line "He let it fall, and it startled him with its booming loudness.", what does "loudness" most nearly mean?

A. the quality of being loud

B. conspicuously or grossly unconventional or unusual

C. fixed; concentrated (on a target)

D. covered overhead like a canopy

Key: A (the quality of being loud)

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Middle School	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18	recall 12, inference 3, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	7, 10, 5, 4, 12, 8, 11, 9, 1, 6, 2, 14, 15, 13, 19, 17, 16, 20	recall 11, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	5, 9, 4, 6, 7, 1, 3, 11, 8, 2, 15, 14, 13, 17, 16, 19, 20, 21	recall 10, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	5, 3, 12, 6, 11, 9, 8, 1, 4, 15, 13, 14, 17, 19, 22, 16, 18, 20	recall 9, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	8, 10, 9, 5, 6, 12, 3, 2, 14, 13, 15, 19, 17, 16, 22, 21, 23, 20	recall 8, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	5, 11, 24, 8, 25, 2, 9, 13, 15, 14, 22, 17, 19, 16, 23, 18, 21, 20	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Freshman	26, 11, 25, 2, 10, 1, 3, 13, 15, 14, 17, 16, 19, 22, 20, 21, 23, 18	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4

College Sophomore	11, 6, 25, 27, 12, 4, 10, 15, 14, 13, 19, 16, 17, 22, 18, 21, 23, 20	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Junior	10, 12, 7, 1, 8, 2, 3, 15, 14, 13, 19, 16, 22, 17, 18, 23, 21, 20	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Senior	1, 8, 5, 3, 27, 9, 6, 14, 13, 15, 22, 16, 19, 17, 18, 20, 23, 21	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
Graduate / PhD	27, 6, 25, 7, 10, 26, 9, 15, 14, 13, 16, 17, 19, 22, 18, 23, 20, 21	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4

Final paper

The Most Dangerous Game: final paper (formal literary analysis). Choose one prompt.

1. Analyze how Richard Connell develops hunter and hunted across The Most Dangerous Game. Trace the idea through at least three moments (beginning, middle and end) and argue what the ending finally suggests.
2. Choose one recurring symbol, image or motif in The Most Dangerous Game and argue how its meaning changes over the story and why that change matters to civilization and savagery.
3. Analyze a central character's choices in The Most Dangerous Game. Argue whether the story judges that character, and how its structure or point of view shapes your answer.
4. Two readers disagree about whether The Most Dangerous Game finally endorses or criticizes its society's view of survival. Weigh both readings and argue for one, answering the strongest objection.

Length: Middle School 500-700 words; HS Freshman 700-900 words; HS Sophomore 900-1,100 words; HS Junior 1,000-1,300 words; HS Senior 1,200-1,500 words; AP 1,300-1,600 words; College Freshman 1,500-2,000 words; College Sophomore 2,000-2,500 words; College Junior 2,500-3,000 words; College Senior 3,000-4,000 words; Graduate / PhD 4,000-6,000 words

Evidence requirement: at least 4 quotations from at least two parts of the story. Quote the reading text exactly and cite the paragraph (MLA style). HS Senior and above: one scholarly or historical source; College Sophomore and above: two, cited in MLA.

Criterion	Points	Descriptor
Thesis	20	A specific, arguable claim that answers the prompt and organizes the paper.
Evidence	25	Well-chosen, accurately quoted and cited passages from across the work, meeting the evidence requirement.
Analysis	30	Explains how language, structure and literary elements create meaning; goes beyond summary.
Organization	15	Logical progression, clear topic sentences and transitions; introduction and conclusion frame the argument.
Style and conventions	10	Formal academic voice, present tense for literature, correct grammar and MLA format.

Essay assignments

Essay: Hunter and hunted

Middle School (600 words; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Most Dangerous Game teaches about hunter and hunted. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Richard Connell develops hunter and hunted in The Most Dangerous Game. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Richard Connell develops hunter and hunted across The Most Dangerous Game. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Most Dangerous Game (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of hunter and hunted. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of hunter and hunted in The Most Dangerous Game. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Richard Connell's choices in The Most Dangerous Game (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of hunter and hunted, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Indiana 2023: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Most Dangerous Game's treatment of hunter and hunted in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Indiana 2023: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on hunter and hunted in The Most Dangerous Game that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Indiana 2023: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on hunter and hunted in The Most Dangerous Game. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Indiana 2023: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about hunter and hunted in The Most Dangerous Game, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Indiana 2023: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on hunter and hunted in The Most Dangerous Game, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Civilization and savagery

Middle School (600 words; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Most Dangerous Game teaches about civilization and savagery. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Richard Connell develops civilization and savagery in The Most Dangerous Game. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Richard Connell develops civilization and savagery across The Most Dangerous Game. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Most Dangerous Game (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of civilization and savagery. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of civilization and savagery in The Most Dangerous Game. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Richard Connell's choices in The Most Dangerous Game (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of civilization and savagery, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Indiana 2023: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Most Dangerous Game's treatment of civilization and savagery in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Indiana 2023: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on civilization and savagery in The Most Dangerous Game that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Indiana 2023: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on civilization and savagery in The Most Dangerous Game. Name your critical method, apply it closely,

and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Indiana 2023: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about civilization and savagery in The Most Dangerous Game, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

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Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Survival

Middle School (600 words; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Most Dangerous Game teaches about survival. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Richard Connell develops survival in The Most Dangerous Game. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Richard Connell develops survival across The Most Dangerous Game. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Most Dangerous Game (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of survival. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of survival in The Most Dangerous Game. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Richard Connell's choices in The Most Dangerous Game (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of survival, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Indiana 2023: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Most Dangerous Game's treatment of survival in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Indiana 2023: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on survival in The Most Dangerous Game that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

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Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

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